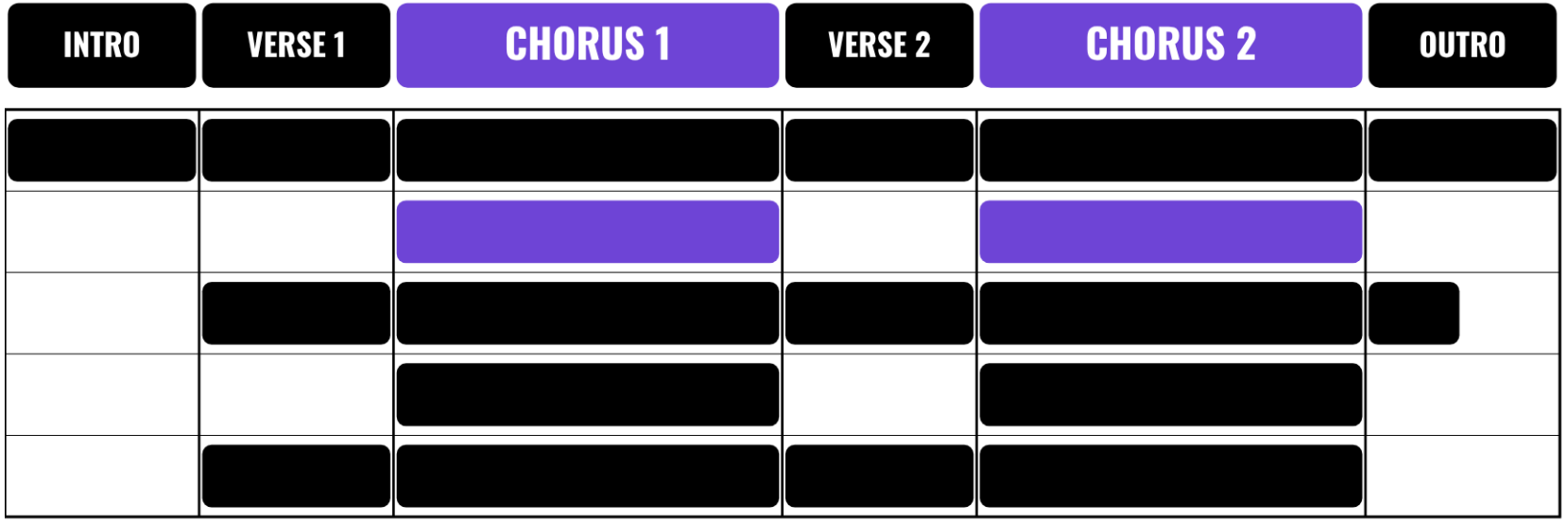
HUDSON BEAT



SONG FORM

Feat. Blinding Lights

WHAT THE HECK IS SONG FORM?

- The overall structure of a song
- How its sections are organized, beginning to end
- Intro · verse · chorus · bridge · outro
- Sections feel different because of what is playing

LISTEN: FEEL THE CHANGE

CRAZY

Gnarls Barkley

Teacher: play the first 2–3 minutes from YouTube or Spotify.

- Raise your hand when the section changes
- What came in? What dropped out?
- Count the measures: what number keeps showing up?

WHAT EACH SECTION DOES

INTRO

Earns attention. Starts sparse and builds.

VERSE

The setup. Sparser than the chorus.

PRE-CHORUS

Optional. Builds tension before the chorus.

CHORUS

The peak. Fuller, louder, same every time.

BRIDGE

Breaks the pattern once, before the last chorus.

OUTRO

Brings it home. Strips back. Ends cleanly.

LISTEN: SONG 2

BLINDING LIGHTS

The Weeknd

Teacher: play the first 2–3 minutes from YouTube or Spotify.

- You lead the labeling this time
- Same structure as Crazy? What is different?
- Why does the chorus feel bigger?

YOUR TURN: TWO SONGS ON YOUR OWN

CRAZY · Gnarls Barkley

SECTION	Intro	Verse	Chorus	Verse	Chorus	Verse	Chorus	Outro
MEASURES	1	16	8	16	8	16	8	8

A finished table looks like this (class example). Now pick two of these. Find them on YouTube or Spotify:

ANTI-HERO — Taylor Swift

GOOD 4 U — Olivia Rodrigo

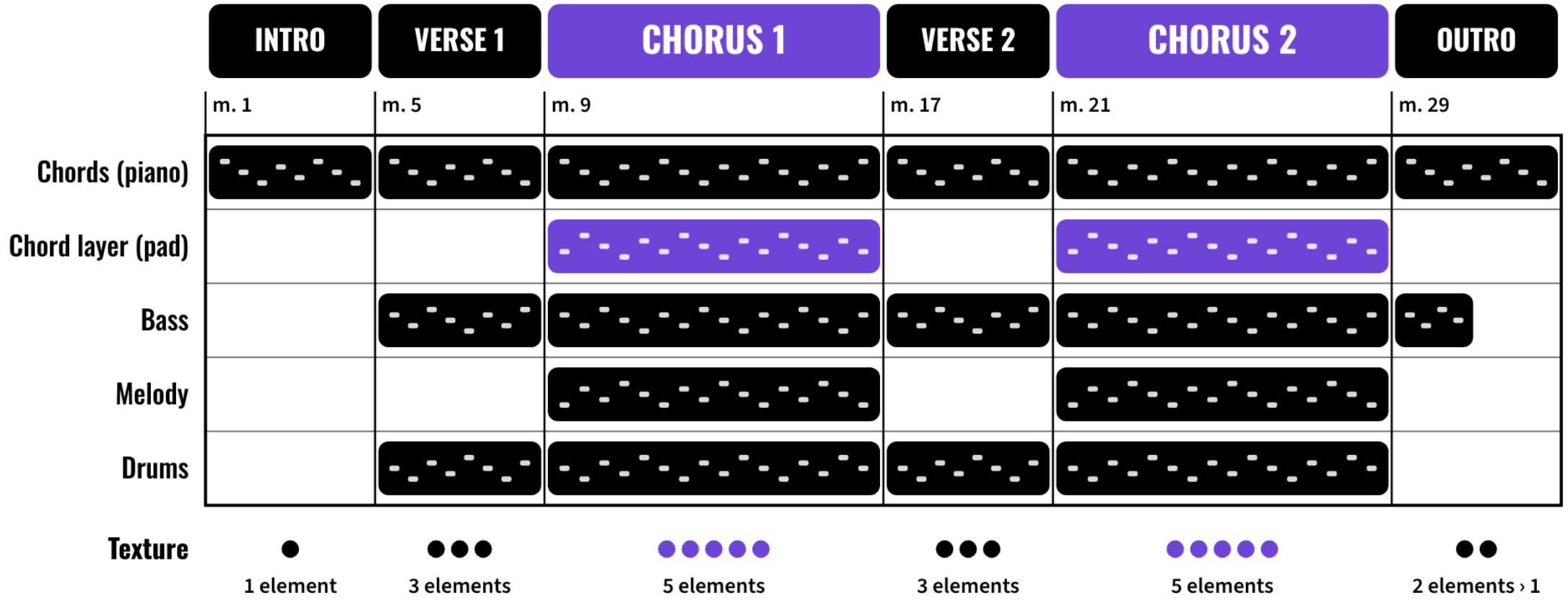
LEVITATING — Dua Lipa

UPTOWN FUNK — Bruno Mars

WHAT SHOWED UP EVERY TIME?

- Sections are almost always 4 or 8 bars
- The chorus is fuller than the verse
- Intros build in; outros strip back
- Write it down: your written response

ARRANGEMENT = WHAT PLAYS WHERE



The worked example: one lane per element, one column per section. Violet = the chord layer.

WATCH ME: THE CHORD LAYER

1. Option-drag a chord region onto a new track below
2. Change the instrument: a pad, a Rhodes, a slow-attack synth
3. Play both together: thicker, same notes
4. Mute the second track in the verse, unmute it in the chorus
5. Play it all: can you hear the chorus get bigger?

WORKED EXAMPLE: A 32-MEASURE SKELETON

SECTION	BARS	ELEMENTS PLAYING chords / bass / melody / drums / chord layer	TRANSITION INTO NEXT SECTION
INTRO	**4**	chords	**Fill:** a one-measure drum fill in m. 4 brings the drums in
VERSE 1	**4**	chords, bass, drums	**Build:** snare on every eighth note in m. 8, rising into the chorus
CHORUS 1	**8**	chords, chord layer, bass, melody, drums	**Cut:** everything stops on beat 4 of m. 16
VERSE 2	**4**	chords, bass, drums	**Fill:** a drum fill in m. 20
CHORUS 2	**8**	chords, chord layer, bass, melody, drums	**Breakdown:** the drums and the pad drop out after m. 28
BRIDGE (OPTIONAL)	–	not used in this skeleton	
OUTRO	**4**	chords, bass (first 2 measures)	**End:** the bass drops out after m. 30; the last chord rings on the I chord

PLAN BEFORE YOU BUILD

- Every section needs a name and a length
- …a list of what is playing
- …and a transition into the next one
- Fill in the planning table on paper first
- No arrangement work in Logic until your plan is checked

FOUR WAYS TO CHANGE SECTIONS

1

FILL

a short drum pattern that leads into the next section

2

BREAKDOWN

elements drop out so the next section hits harder

3

CUT

everything stops for a beat, then the new section starts

4

BUILD

energy rises (snare roll, rising notes) into the next section

DAY 2

YOUR PROJECT: SONG FORM

- Four songs on the Song Form sheet + a written response
- Plan 4+ sections, each 4+ measures
- Build it in Logic with arrangement markers
- Make the chorus feel bigger than the verse

THE STEPS

DAY 1

SONG FORM ANALYSIS: A LISTENING DAY

Listen to 4 songs and map their form on the Song Form sheet; write what you noticed

DAY 2

PLAN + BUILD THE SKELETON

Add your melody, fill in the planning table, build the skeleton with arrangement markers

DAY 3

DIFFERENTIATE THE SECTIONS

Chord layer, melody only where it belongs, a drum transition at every change

DAY 4

FINISH, SUBMIT, PRESENT

Finish the mix, export and submit, present: point to your chorus

WHAT YOU TURN IN

- [ ] Song Form sheet: 4 songs + written response
- [ ] Planning table, filled in before building
- [ ] 4+ sections with arrangement markers, 4+ measures each
- [ ] Chord layer on a second instrument + a transition at every change
- [ ] MP3 + compressed .logicx, named Your Name – Song Form
- [ ] Three feedback questions before presenting

HOW IT'S SCORED

SONG FORM ANALYSIS	5 = All four sheets accurate; the written response shows real insight into song structure.	/ 5
SONG FORM STRUCTURE	5 = A clearly planned, complete song with a beginning, middle and end.	/ 5
SECTION DIFFERENTIATION	5 = Distinct textures: a listener can name the section by ear.	/ 5
ARRANGEMENT AS MIX	5 = Arrangement and mix work as one; nothing is clipping.	/ 5
DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION	5 = On time, named correctly; explains form choices section by section; three feedback questions.	/ 5

TOTAL / 25

ONE LAST THING...

- Sections feel different because of what is playing.
- Write once, arrange many times.
- You built the form yourself.

